DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY



OPPOSITION OUTRAGE
A BJP team led by Bharati Ghosh visits the victim's home in Hanskhali, Nadia

LITANY OF HORROR

MARCH 3
Class 4 student allegedly raped at Sagardwip. Accused is a Trinamool Congress worker

MARCH 22
Tribal woman in Basirhat raped by TMC worker

MARCH 24
17-year-old raped multiple times in Basirhat. Accused is TMC leader

APRIL 1
14-year-old Madrassa student allegedly gangraped in Harishchandrapur. Accused associated with TMC.

APRIL 1
Health worker raped at Galsi, Burdwan. Local police, TMC leaders allegedly threatened her against lodging a complaint.

APRIL 4
A minor allegedly raped by son of influential TMC leader in Hanskhali, Nadia

APRIL 10
A tribal minor raped multiple times at Bolpur. TMC leader arrested.

APRIL 11
Alleged rape attempt on differently abled woman at Pingla, West Midnapore by local panchayat member

APRIL 11
Class 9 student allegedly raped by TMC supporters.

APRIL 14
Tribal girl gangraped while returning from fair

APRIL 15
Minor girl survives rape attempt, sets herself on fire as political leaders allegedly pressure her to withdraw case

APRIL 16
Burdwan: Woman allegedly abducted, sexually assaulted in moving vehicle. Two TMC workers arrested.

made after the Park Street rape case in February 2012. After a woman returning from a night club was gangraped by five men in a car, Mamata made light of the incident, trying to play it down as "fabricated" and "minor".

Senior TMC leaders Saugata Roy and Mahua Moitra added to the gasps of horror by speaking out against the rising graph of atrocities against women. As Mamata is in charge of the home portfolio, their remarks have created a flutter in the TMC leadership.

Visiting the family of the Hanskhali victim, Moitra, the MP from Krishnanagar, Nadia, said, "The question of consent is being talked about. Even consensual sex with a minor is illegal; it is rape in the eyes of law." It was in complete departure from what Mamata hinted at. "As a party MP...I will not tolerate such things. The only identity of the accused is that he's a criminal," she added. Dum Dum MP Roy was even more direct. "In a state that has a woman chief minister, if any incident of atrocity on women occurs under her leadership, it is a matter of shame for all of us," he said. Predictably, some TMC leaders rushed to Mamata's defence. MP Satabdi Roy said atrocities on women had nothing to do with the gender of a chief minister. "Does the chief minister want such incidents to occur?" she said. State vice-president Jay Prakash Majumdar echoed her.

A TMC VETERAN SAYS MAMATA REGRETTED HER WORDS AND SENT MOITRA TO NADIA TO SEND A MESSAGE

Two related explanations about the motives behind Moitra and Roy's statements are doing the rounds. The first is that Moitra and Roy, both reportedly close to Mamata's nephew and TMC general secretary Abhishek Banerjee, were rushed in for damage control by a section of the party. A party veteran, however, confided that Mamata herself regretted her words and sent her party MP from Nadia (Moitra) to iterate the party's stand of zero tolerance to such incidents. Be that as it may, their remarks have caused some embarrassment to the party.

The BJP, still smarting at the loss in the assembly poll, sundry bypolls, civic polls and, most recently, in bypolls to the Asansol and Ballygunge seats, grabbed the opening with alacrity. The central leadership promptly sent a National Commission for Women fact-finding